



Workshop

04
MAY
2026

Philology Meets AI: Deciphering Rare Scripts

This workshop is an interdisciplinary forum that explores the intersection of philology and automation.

While advances in artificial intelligence and computer vision have transformed our capacity to process historical sources, the task of understanding rare scripts remains fundamentally philological. The workshop examines the linguistic and contextual foundations that determine how automation can, or cannot, be effectively applied to ancient, fragmented, and undeciphered texts.

Format

The **workshop** will feature invited talks, discussion, and hands-on demonstrations of annotated materials and decipherment case studies. The event designed for (digital) philologists, palaeographers, epigraphers, and researchers in AI, interested in bridging the gap between interpretive scholarship and machine-based analysis.

By **grounding** automation in deep humanistic understanding, we aim to ensure that future AI systems respect the complexity, variability, and beauty of the world's rare writing traditions.

Focus and Objectives

- Explore philological approaches to rare and undeciphered scripts
- Discuss the limits of digital abstraction and the importance of human interpretation
- Identify how philological expertise can inform data modeling and annotation strategies
- Build a shared vocabulary between humanists and computer scientists working on script analysis

Location [Pärlan, Building 4, Albano, Stockholm University, Stockholm](#)

Registration Jotform:
<https://eu.jotform.com/build/260204664761354>

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Stockholm
University

Department of Linguistics



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Organizers

Beáta Megyesi, Stockholm University, Sweden
Crina Tudor, Stockholm University, Sweden
Michelle Waldispühl, University of Oslo, Norway

Invited speakers

Gian Pietro Basello, L'Orientale University of Naples, Italy
Logan Born, Canada
Micaella Bruton, Stockholm University, Sweden
François Desset, University of Liège – University of Teheran – Archéorient, Lyon, France
Alicia Fornés, CVC, Autonomous University of Barcelona, Spain
Raphaella Heil, Stockholm University, Sweden
Benedek Láng, ELTE, Hungary
Kathryn Kelley, Uppsala University, Sweden
Nils Kopal, HS Niederrhein, Germany
David Osgarby, University of Glasgow, Scotland, UK
Filippo Pedron, University of Helsinki, Finland
Rune Rattenborg, Lund University, Sweden
Wout Sinneave, University of Oslo, Norway
Oreen Yousuf, Uppsala University, Sweden

Acknowledgments

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Program

09:30-10:00 Welcome and Introduction to the DESCRYPT Program – by Beáta Megyesi
10:00-10:45 Rare Scripts of the World – by Rune Rattenborg and Michelle Waldispühl
10:45-11:15 Language vs. Writing: How do Diverse Visual Communication Strategies Shape Decipherment Methodologies? – by Kathryn Kelley
11:15-11:45 Shorthands and Artificial Languages and Writings – by Benedek Láng

11:45-13:00 Lunch

13:00-13:45 The Transcription of Writing Systems: Computational Challenges – by Alicia Fornés and Raphaella Heil
13:45-14:30 The Automatic Decipherment of Rare Writings: The DecryptTool – by Nils Kopal

14:30-15:00 Break

15:00-15:45 The Decipherment of Linear Elamite – by Gian Pietro Basello and François Desset
15:45-16:30 The Automatic Analysis of Proto Elamite – by Logan Born

16:30-17:00 Break

17:00-18:30 Invited presentations about PhD projects related to the decipherment of rare scripts
The Decipherment of Ciphers with Neural Models – by Micaella Bruton
Laying the Groundwork for Pictish Symbol Decipherment: Insights from Building and Analysing Comparable Graphematic and Linguistic Corpora – by David Osgarby
The Adoption and Adaptation of Cuneiform Writing to Write Elamite – by Filippo Pedron
Digitisation and Restoration of Runic Inscriptions Using HTR and Transformer Models – by Wout Sinneave
Ajami Manuscripts – by Oreen Yousuf
18:30-18:45 Closing



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